ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

LIN 101: Introduction to Linguistics - Sound, Structure and Meaning

Analyse language systematically instead of judging it

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Linguistics | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Linguistics is descriptive, not prescriptive. This pack introduces phonetics and phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics and sociolinguistics, using Nigerian languages and Nigerian English as data - so the examples are close to what you actually hear.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Transcribe simple words using IPA.
- Identify morphemes and word-formation processes.
- Draw a basic syntactic tree.
- Explain the difference between descriptive and prescriptive approaches.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Phonetics and phonology

Sounds first, then the systems they form.

- Articulation: place and manner of consonants, voicing.
- Vowels described by height, backness and rounding.
- IPA symbols for sounds that English spelling hides.
- Phoneme versus allophone: contrast versus variation.
- Syllable structure, stress and tone.
- Nigerian languages contribute sounds English lacks; use them as data.

Morphology and syntax

Structure at word level and sentence level.

- Morpheme: free and bound; root, stem and affix.
- Word formation: derivation, compounding, borrowing, reduplication, clipping.
- Word classes identified by distribution, not only meaning.
- Constituents and phrase structure.
- Basic tree diagrams for simple sentences.
- Grammaticality is judged against a grammar, not against taste.

> **Describe, do not scold**
> 'Ain't' and Nigerian English forms are data about rules in use. Prescriptivism belongs to style guidance, not linguistic analysis.

Semantics and sociolinguistics

Meaning and social life are part of language structure.

- Sense, reference and ambiguity.
- Synonymy, antonymy, hyponymy and entailment.
- Pragmatics: implicature and speech acts.
- Variation by region, class, gender and context.
- Code-switching and multilingual repertoires.
- Language contact, pidginisation and creolisation.

Language as a system, not a list of rules

Linguistics studies language as a natural object. Its central claim is that every human language is a structured system with levels that can be analysed separately: phonetics (the sounds themselves), phonology (how sounds pattern), morphology (how words are built), syntax (how sentences are built), semantics (meaning) and pragmatics (meaning in use).

The discipline is descriptive, not prescriptive. A linguist does not ask whether "I no go school" is correct English but what system produces it and who uses it with whom. Judgements about correctness are social facts worth studying, but they are not linguistic analysis.

Descriptivism does not mean anything goes. Every language, dialect and pidgin has systematic rules, and a speaker who breaks them produces something that other speakers recognise as wrong. The difference between "he don go" and "he dey go" is grammatical, not a matter of taste.

Phonetics and phonology: the sounds and the patterns